DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Face to Face: Why Are We God's Partners?

Daat Tevunot §158

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §158 (continued; section 8, part 2) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 7 September 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

We are in section 8 of the book, page 488 in the English edition, beginning its second part, in the middle of §158.

The Rabbi recalled what the previous class established. Section 7 dealt with the emanations (hashpaot) that come from outside and act upon the world. Section 8 deals with a different force: the force within every creature that sustains it and keeps it in existence. The main purpose of creation is the human being, and within humanity the Jewish people. This sustaining force comes from HaKadosh Barukh Hu and lets the Neshamah give life to the body, which is why it is called "the soul of souls". It has a dual nature: depending on how a person lives, it can be elevated or debased.

Two sets of forces that mirror each other

The Sekhel now adds that the main purpose of all the emanations is the Jewish people, as the verse says, "Your wonders and Your thoughts are towards us." So the two kinds of force, those of section 7 acting on the world and those of section 8 sustaining it, are parallel and work in tandem.

The English summary puts the key line clearly: the dynamics of the relationship between God and the Jewish people are reflected in the relationship between these two kinds of emanation. When that relationship is close, the sustaining force is strong, and that in turn strengthens the emanations that come down upon the world.

A participant summed it up: when the individual does good, it goes back up, and what comes down is the result. "Precisely," said the Rabbi. This is a deeper version of what we learned long ago in Derech Hashem.

Free will: the one thing in our hands

Every creature exists only because God wills it and gives it shefa. Animals have no choice; a lion does what lions do. Even the pure souls before they enter the body cannot choose. Only the

human being has free will, as Hazal say in the Gemara: "Everything is in the hands of Heaven except the fear of Heaven."

In one sense we are like the animals: if God stopped willing our existence for a moment, we would cease to be. In another sense we are completely independent, because how we live is up to us.

The Rabbi linked this to the principle that one who is commanded and does a misvah is greater than one who is not commanded. On a simple level, the commanded person has a stronger yeser hara to overcome. On a deeper level, the person who is commanded is part of the system of emanations, so his actions create the ripple effect. Someone outside that system finds it much harder to do so.

Partners and familiarity

Because we choose, God made the righteous His partners, as it were, in rectifying the world. The Zohar reads the verse in Yeshayahu, "You are My nation" (ammi atah), as "You are with Me" (immi atah): you work with Me. HaKadosh Barukh Hu could do it alone, but the main way the world reaches its tikkun is through this partnership. The Rabbi stressed that "saddikim" here does not mean only great saddikim. It means anyone who does the will of the Almighty.

A partnership brings familiarity. Someone who only ever receives from another feels ashamed before him. A partner can stand before the king with a certain pride. The souls before they enter the body are holy and cleave to God, but they are like a servant who only takes. Human beings, and the Jewish people especially with their many misvot, are partners and therefore close.

The king's audience: degrees of "face to face"

The Ramhal brings the Zohar's parable about prayer. Some servants are not dear to the king. They can send a message from outside the chamber, and the king may even grant the request, but he will not see them. Another servant is dear, and the king gives him an audience face to face.

The Rabbi drew out the verses. Moshe tells the people at the end of his life, "Face to face Hashem spoke with you at the mountain." But of Moshe alone the Torah says, "face to face, as a man speaks to his friend." That second phrase appears only with Moshe, which is why his prophecy was of a different kind. Even a dear servant is still a servant; a friend is something else. After the sin of the golden calf, God tells Moshe, "You will see My back, but My face will not be seen."

The Rabbi described the many degrees of "face to face": with a thick partition, a thin one, none at all; looking up at someone as a student looks at a teacher; the guard at the palace who sees the king but must keep his distance; and finally the king's own children and friends. In ordinary life too, "Look me in the eye" expresses a relationship. Turning one's face away expresses distance.

He added a source he was surprised the Ramhal did not bring: the Keruvim. When Israel did the will of the Almighty, the Keruvim faced one another.

The Ramhal's summary (point 26)

The English summary on page 496 ties it together. When we use free choice to turn towards God and perfect the world, we create a relationship of face to face, and closeness between the two sets of emanations. The sustaining force can then receive an outpouring of blessing, which floods down into the world. When we turn away, the two sets of forces turn back to back, the blessing cannot be received, and the world falls into spiritual darkness.

"Beautiful, how it all comes together," said the Rabbi. The more intensely we are face to face, the more we become partners, and the more blessing comes down. The opposite is also true.

Asked whether real "face to face" belongs only to the time of perfection, the Rabbi agreed that there are levels: even now there can be a distant kind of face to face, and there will always be a limit to how close it can get.

Summary

- Section 8's sustaining force and section 7's emanations upon the world mirror each other, and both depend on the relationship between God and the Jewish people.
- Only human beings have free will ("everything is in the hands of Heaven except the fear of Heaven"), and this is what lets us affect the system.
- Through free choice the righteous become God's partners in the tikkun of the world, and partnership brings familiarity.
- Closeness is described as "face to face" and distance as "back to back", with many degrees in between; only Moshe spoke with God "as a man speaks to his friend".
- When we are face to face, blessing flows into the world; when we turn away, the world falls into darkness.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/0r5MILhS7bA · More shiurim: rabbikada.com